

CA.4 Where to File Directory

The offices a California owner-builder deals with, how to find each one for your parcel, and a page to write down what you confirmed.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. California writes one building code for the whole state — Title 24 — but permits are issued by 58 counties and hundreds of incorporated cities, and state law lets each of them amend that code for local conditions. Confirm every item with the city or county building department that will issue your permit before you rely on it.

WHO ISSUES YOUR PERMIT DEPENDS ON WHERE YOUR LOT IS

The building code is statewide; permits are not issued by the State. Every statute that touches the permit addresses it to local government — B&P § 7031.5 to "*each county or city*," Health & Safety Code § 19825 to "*every city, county, or city and county*," Education Code § 17620(b) to "*a city or county*." In practice: if your parcel sits **inside the limits of an incorporated city**, the city issues. If it is in the **unincorporated county**, the county does. Some small cities contract their building services back to the county, so the counter you stand at may not be the one you expect.

Settle this first — it decides everything else

Before you gather a single document, confirm **which jurisdiction issues your permit**. There is no single statewide parcel viewer, but there is a fast official check: the tax-rate lookup at maps.cdtfa.ca.gov takes a street address and tells you whether it sits in an incorporated city or in the unincorporated county. Confirm it against your county assessor's parcel viewer, which is definitive because the assessor assigns the APN — then call that building department and confirm it out loud. Filing with the wrong office costs you weeks, and in California weeks are expensive.

Ask the same call two more questions: **which Title 24 edition** they are currently enforcing, and whether they have **local amendments** on file. Both answers change what you draw.

HOW TO FIND EACH OFFICE

Finding the right office for your parcel

Office	How to find it
Building department (permits, plan review, inspection scheduling)	Search "[your city] CA building department" or "[your county] CA building and safety." Most California jurisdictions run an online permit portal; ask which one and register before you file.
Planning / zoning (setbacks, use, zoning clearance)	Usually a separate department from building, and usually the first stop — many jurisdictions require a planning clearance before building will accept your application at all.
Environmental health (septic, private wells)	Search "[your county] environmental health septic." This is a county function even if your parcel is inside a city. Ask whether the county runs an approved LAMP under the State Water Board's OWTS Policy — the Board publishes a LAMP contact list at waterboards.ca.gov . Wells are permitted locally too: the Department of Water Resources sets the standards but issues nothing, and keeps a county-by-county list of permitting agencies at water.ca.gov .
Fire authority (access, water supply, WUI, sprinklers)	Could be a city fire department, a county fire department, an independent fire protection district, or CAL FIRE in the State Responsibility Area. Ask your building department which one reviews your project, and whether they or the fire authority inspect the sprinkler system. Check your parcel's zone and responsibility area on the official viewer linked from osfm.fire.ca.gov , not on a listing.
School district (the fee certification that gates your permit)	Find the district whose boundary contains the parcel — the county office of education can tell you, and it is not always the nearest school. Ask for the current per-square-foot rate and what they need to issue the certificate.
Public works (driveway, encroachment, grading, address)	Establish who maintains the road you will connect to: city, county, or the State. A connection onto a state highway is a Caltrans encroachment permit (dot.ca.gov). Your Regional Water Quality Control Board — one of nine, found from waterboards.ca.gov — decides whether your land disturbance needs the Construction General Permit, enrolled at smarts.waterboards.ca.gov .

Sources (verified August 2026; statutes at leginfo.legislature.ca.gov). Permit-issuing authority is local: B&P § 7031.5; H&S § 19825(a); Education Code § 17620(b); and H&S § 17960 — "The building department of every city or county shall enforce within its jurisdiction all the provisions published in the State Building Standards Code." School district certification gates the building permit, or the final inspection and certificate of occupancy where the district elected the Government Code § 66007(a) alternative — § 17620(c). Local amendments are filed with the Building Standards Commission, fire district findings with HCD — CRC § 1.1.8.1. Every domain in this document resolved in August 2026; navigate from the domain, not a printed deep link.

YOUR DIRECTORY — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

Confirm each entry by telephone rather than copying it from a search result, and write down the date and the name of the person you spoke to — in a California permitting office a name is worth more than a number.

BUILDING DEPARTMENT — issues the permit; schedules inspections

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PLANNING / ZONING — setbacks, zoning clearance, address assignment

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

COUNTY ENVIRONMENTAL HEALTH — septic and private well

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

FIRE AUTHORITY — access, water supply, WUI construction, sprinklers

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

SCHOOL DISTRICT — fee certification — gates your permit or your CO

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

PUBLIC WORKS / ENCROACHMENT — driveway, grading, road connection

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ELECTRIC UTILITY / WATER / SEWER — temporary power, permanent service, connection and will-serve

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

ENERGY CONSULTANT / ECC-RATER — Title 24 compliance and verification

Office / department: _____ Phone: _____

Portal / address: _____ Spoke with: _____ Confirmed: _____

STATE-LEVEL CONTACTS

These are stable and worth knowing. Phone numbers are left for you to confirm — a wrong number printed in a kit is worse than no number.

State agencies and what each is actually for

Agency	Why you would contact them	Website
Contractors State License Board (CSLB)	Verify the license of every contractor you hire, in the right classification, before work starts and again before final payment. Also publishes owner-builder guidance and takes reports of unlicensed activity.	cslb.ca.gov
California Building Standards Commission	Publishes Title 24 and its effective dates, and is where cities and counties must file their local amendments (CRC § 1.1.8.1). It publishes a searchable ordinance list per code cycle — search your city or county by name to see what it amended.	dgs.ca.gov/BSC
Dept of Housing and Community Development (HCD)	Adopts the residential building standards you are built to, and runs the factory-built and manufactured housing programs. Fire district amendment findings are filed here.	hcd.ca.gov
California Energy Commission	The Energy Code, approved compliance software, and the CF1R / CF2R / CF3R compliance documents. Since January 2026 the verification program is the Energy Code Compliance Program — ask for an ECC-Rater , not a HERS rater.	energy.ca.gov
State Water Resources Control Board	The OWTS Policy that governs septic, and the list of local agencies running approved LAMPs. Also the Construction General Permit for stormwater, enrolled through SMARTS.	waterboards.ca.gov smarts.waterboards.ca.gov
CAL FIRE and the Office of the State Fire Marshal	Fire hazard severity zone maps — check your parcel here, not on a listing — defensible space guidance, and the listings of building products approved for wildland-urban interface use.	fire.ca.gov osfm.fire.ca.gov
Board of Forestry and Fire Protection	Writes the defensible space regulations. It adopted the Zone 0 ember-resistant rules on 19 August 2026, effective on filing — expected around September 2026. Confirm current status here before you finalize a site plan.	bof.fire.ca.gov
Coastal Commission · Caltrans · Dept of Water Resources	A Coastal Development Permit is a separate approval on its own timeline in the Coastal Zone. Caltrans issues the encroachment permit if your driveway meets a state highway. DWR sets well standards and lists the county agencies that permit wells.	coastal.ca.gov dot.ca.gov water.ca.gov